Strategic Modeling — Module 03: Perception — Discussion Questions

20 questions on competitive intelligence, weak signals, and strategic sensing.

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1. How did Kodak's generative model filter out the weak signal of digital imaging despite having invented the technology?
2. What is the difference between data and strategic intelligence? How does the transformation happen?
3. When is broad environmental scanning (looking everywhere) more valuable than focused monitoring (tracking known competitors)?
4. How do you detect "weak signals" when they are by definition ambiguous and fragmentary?
5. What organizational structures support strategic perception? Which structures hinder it?
6. How does the speed of environmental change affect how an organization should design its sensing systems?
7. Design a competitive intelligence system for an organization entering a new market.
8. How do cognitive biases (confirmation bias, success bias) distort strategic perception? Give examples.
9. When should an organization invest in "sensing the periphery" versus deeply understanding its core market?
10. How do intelligence failures (missing disruptive threats) trace back to perceptual filtering rather than information availability?
11. Identify three weak signals in your industry that could indicate significant future changes.
12. Conduct a perceptual blind spot audit: What information is your organization systematically ignoring or filtering out?
13. Design a "sensing dashboard" that monitors your industry's key uncertainties.
14. Compare how a market leader and a challenger should configure their environmental scanning differently.

15. How can organizations avoid the trap of "analysis paralysis" — gathering information without converting it to strategic action?
16. What role do external advisors, board members, and consultants play in expanding organizational perception?
17. How does social media change the competitive intelligence landscape? What new signals are available?
18. Design an experiment that would test whether your organization's competitive sensing is faster or slower than your main competitor's.
19. When a major prediction turns out wrong, what should the organization learn about its sensing process?
20. How do you balance the cost of competitive intelligence systems with their strategic value?